

Gastornis

Fifty million years ago, when Europe and North America were covered with lush tropical forests, a giant flightless bird prowled through the undergrowth. *Gastornis* was taller than a man and had a head as large as a horse's. Its beak was gigantic and its bite immensely powerful—but whether it used it to tear flesh, crack bones, or merely munch on leaves remains an unsolved mystery.



Footprint on sandstone

In 2009, a 50-million-year-old footprint made by *Gastornis* was found in a slab of rock in Washington State. To protect the find from rainy weather and fossil thieves, the slab was airlifted in a helicopter to Western Washington University, where it now lies safely.

